

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, February 12, 2024, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward II Councilor Brian Zutter
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Hayden
Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor William Greenrose
At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway
At-Large Councilor William Limoges
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

Yoshi Manale, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

Councilor O’Hearne asked to take off New Business Items: D, E, and F and address how to proceed with 79-E’s.

Councilor Koloski asked if there were applicants present tonight.

Mayor Girard stated if council agrees it will be moved to another meeting.

Councilor Hayden asked what would the discussion be.

Mayor Girard stated the Council will be discussing the City’s 79-E process relative to the State RSA.

Assistant Mayor Matteau had concern with delays in projects, and suggested to discuss the concerns Council has tonight.

Consensus of the Council to address 79-E program tonight.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Hemingway to accept the minutes of the January 22nd, 2025, City Council meeting.

Roll call:

**Koloski – yes
Greenrose – abstain
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – abstain
Girard – yes
Motion carried 7-0**

MAYOR’S NOTES

Recognition Award – David Putnam

Mayor Girard read a speech and gave David Putnam a plaque to recognize the volunteer work he did for the City for thirty-five years.

Claremont Senior Center is hosting a turkey dinner this Saturday, doors open at 4:15pm.

Claremont Opera House is hosting two Recycled Percussion shows this Saturday.

The Greater Claremont Chamber of Commerce is hosting their annual awards on Thursday February 20th.

Parks and Recreation will be hosting a father-daughter dance on Friday February 21st at 7:00pm at the Community Center.

CITY MANAGER’S REPORT

Manager Manale thanked the Claremont Police and Fire Departments for emergency planning during this week’s events at Stevens Highschool.

Manager Manale also acknowledged the Department of Public Works for their snow cleanup. Also noting the last storm there were issues with the City side-walk machines and are currently looking into options to prevent this from happening again.

The City is close to closing on 17 Water Street, anticipating the Executive Council Governor should sign off on the purchase at one of their next meetings. The City is working with Fourth Kind Films for promotional video.

Councilor Koloski asked for an update on the CSBCC roof. Director Martin explained experiencing minor leaking and has had about seven different contractors look at it. One is willing to donate the work. However, scheduling is tough with the weather.

Councilor Koloski mentioned one of the exterior lights is hanging off the building of 17 Water Street.

Councilor Hemingway asked about the upcoming budgets, and wants to see an inventory lease schedule. Manager Manale noted the City has contracted with DebtBooks to put this together.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Planning Board

A motion was made by Councilor Hayden and seconded by Councilor Zutter to appoint Margaret Hurley to Seat 8 of the Claremont Planning Board.

Councilor Koloski has concerns with potential law suits. And asked if Ms. Hurley can come up for questions, Council agrees.

Councilor Koloski asked if Ms. Hurley would have the ability to be neutral and recuse herself.

Ms. Hurley replied, absolutely and stated she would expect it from others, and then expect it from herself.

Mayor Girard asked if Ms. Hurley wanted to say anything.

Ms. Hurley stated wanting to be on the Planning Board, and noted being the Planning Commission in Rochester, N.Y. Ms. Hurley also stated Councilor Koloski has an important point of recusal, and takes it seriously, and will self-interrogate by asking herself if the topic is something she has spoken out about publicly, and if so would recuse herself.

Roll call:

Koloski – no

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - no

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – no

Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – no
Girard – no
Motion failed 4-5

Parks and Recreation Board

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Limoges to appoint Mark White to Alternate Seat 7, Ward III of the Claremont Parks and Recreation Commission.

Mark White introduced himself and noted he lived here his whole life, and used to work at Parks and Recreation Department, and recently joined Friends of the Library.

Roll call:
Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0 voice

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Mayor Girard gave reminder that Citizen’s forum is designed to allow you the opportunity to make the Council aware of your concerns. Please state your name and ward number, we ask you to address your concerns directly to the Council. The Council Manager will not be responding to you during this time. You are limited to five minutes on any non-agenda items. In the back of the room please write down your contact information if you’d like to be contacted as well as your concern on the clipboard for follow up.

James Chamberlain, speaking as Fire Chief and Emergency Management Director for the City of Claremont, wants to sincerely commend the local police officers for the job they did yesterday, and wanted to recognize the efforts of the Claremont Police Department, there was a significant event at Stevens High School. The CPD under the leadership of Deputy Chief Chris Allen performed exceptionally well. Deputy had a clear plan and he executed his plan, and he communicated in a cool, calm, and collected manner. With numerous agencies responding, the Deputy maintained full command and executed his strategies in a way that this City should be extremely proud of, and wants to personally commend Deputy Chief Allen and his staff on a job well done.

Jack Hurley, Ward II, concerned with the Planning Board decision, and noted Ms. Hurley answered Councilor Koloski's questions and concerns adequately, and is now concerned for decisions in the future.

Margaret Hurley, Ward II respectfully requested everyone's reason for the vote. Mayor Girard said the Council does not have to answer.

Ms. Hurley asked when she could find out, and wants a transparent government, then mentioned that's part of the problem.

Councilor Koloski stated he will reach out.

Hope Damon, State Representative gave updates from state house.

NEW BUSINESS

CDBG - Claremont's Housing and Community Development Plan and CDBG Citizen Participation Plan. to re-adopt and approve the Housing & Community Development Plan and CDBG Participation Plan – Public Hearing (City Manager)

Mayor Girard noted there was information in the hall for the public.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing.

Mayor Girard asked for public comment, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Mayor Girard read the following from the CDBG script:

Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) funds are available to municipalities through the NH Community Development Finance Authority. Up to \$500,000 annually is available for Economic Development Projects, up to \$500,000 for Housing Projects, up to \$750,000 for Supportive Housing, up to \$500,000 for Public Facility Projects, up to at least \$350,000 in Emergency Funds, up to \$25,000 per Planning Study grant. All CDBG projects must directly benefit a majority of low- and moderate-income persons.

This public hearing is on Claremont's proposed updated Housing and Community Development Plan (HCDP). A Housing and Community Development Plan is required to be eligible to apply for CDBG funds. The proposed Housing and Community Development Plan (HCDP) identifies needs, which currently exist or are anticipated during the next three years. The Plan provides a basis for guiding the City's housing and community development objectives and actions. In addition, the Plan includes a CDBG Citizen Participation plan that details the CDBG requirements for public hearings.

The Housing and Community Development Plan was last adopted in July 2021, no changes have been made.

Motion to Adopt Housing & Community Development Plan and Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) Citizen Participation Plan

The City Council hereby moves to approve and adopt the City's Housing and Community Development Plan and further authorizes the City Manager or his designees to sign and execute all documents related to the Plan.

A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to Adopt Housing & Community Development Plan and Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) Citizen Participation Plan

Roll call:

**Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O'Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0**

Broad Street Monadnock Park Project Presentation – Public Hearing

Austin Ford, City Planner, introduced the Beta Group for a presentation, and noted the point of this presentation is informational and for public comment, nothing needs to be approved by the City Council at this time.

Senior Project Manager Chris Turgeon and John Byatt from the BETA Group presented the following slides:

**Broad Street –
Monadnock Park –
Bobby Woodman Rail
Trail
Improvements**
Claremont, New Hampshire

LOCAL CONCERNS MEETING
February 12, 2025



Agenda

- Purpose of Meeting
- Purpose of the Project
- Survey
- Existing Conditions
- Potential Options
- Other Safety Measures
- Project Development Process
- Schedule
- Questions and Input from Stakeholders

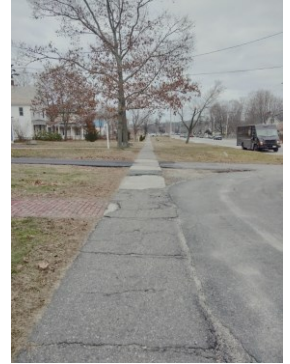
Purpose of Local Concerns Meeting

- For designers to gain input on the project
- No design performed yet
- Input needed to guide design
- Answer questions
- Provide schedule of work



Project Purpose

- City Awarded Transportation Alternatives Program (TAP) Grant in 2021
- Improve safety for pedestrian and bicycles from the rail trail entrance at Marion Phillips Apartments, along Broad Street and through Monadnock Park
- Improve safety and reestablish of existing Bobby Woodman Rail Trail from Chestnut Street entrance to the bridge over the Sugar River
- Improve connectivity of existing pedestrian and bicycle facilities



Project Challenges

- Right-of-Way Impacts along rail trail
- Steep slopes along Monadnock Park driveways
- Potential wetland impacts
- Permitting
- Steep grades along Monadnock Park driveways



Existing Conditions



Existing Conditions



Existing Conditions



Existing Conditions



Existing Conditions – Traffic Volumes

- Traffic counts conducted by City 4/17/2024 to 4/25/2024 at Broad Street/Monadnock Park driveway
- Average weekday ADT 10,221 with 50% distribution

Existing Conditions – Speed Data

Location	Posted Speed Limit	85 th Percentile Speed (MPH)	Average Speed (MPH)
Broad Street at Monadnock Park Driveway	20 MPH	34 MPH	29.9 MPH

Existing Conditions – Crash Data (2019-2024)

Broad Street at Summer Street

- 23 crashes from 2019 to 2024, 4.6 Crashes Per Year
- Moderate crash location close to the Broad Street and Monadnock Park Driveway

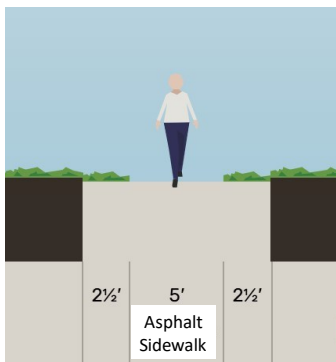


Project Improvements/Alternatives

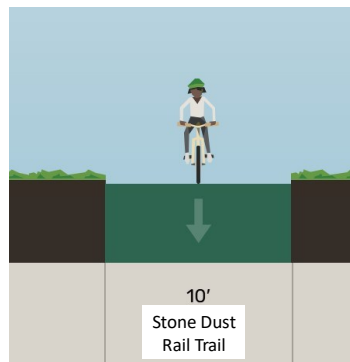


Broad Street Typical

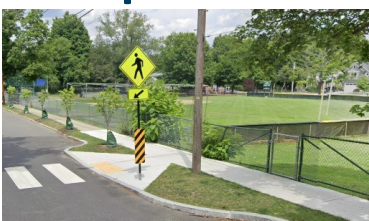
Monadnock Park Path



Rail Trail



Complete Streets Toolbox



Complete Streets Toolbox



Project Development Process

- Engineering Study
 - Evaluate options and develop recommendation
 - Two public meetings
 - Environmental Coordination
- Preliminary Plans
 - Environmental Document
- Final Plans
 - Environmental permitting
 - Right-of-way easements
 - Utility coordination
- Advertise for Construction
- Construction

RAIL TRAIL



Schedule

- Engineering Study complete – October 2025
- Preliminary Plans complete – March 2026
- Final Design, ROW, Permitting – Begin April 2026
- Advertise for April 2027
- Construction – Late Summer/Fall 2027



Funding

- Current NHDOT Budgeted Project Cost - \$1,068,992



Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one from public spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Resolution 2025-32 Spring Capital Plan Acceptance – Public Hearing

Manager Manale explained there were three new items to the Spring Capital Plan. The Capital Reserve for the Monadnock track escrow, its escrow because part of the Capital Improvement Plan did note that the cost would be about \$67,000.00 for the track, but have determined the true cost is not just the resurfacing it has to be completely re-done. This allows time to build up funds and to potentially find federal grants.

Director Martin noted upon reviewing the CIP items - last time the track was resurfaced it cost around \$60,000.00. and \$67,000.00 was placed by previous directors. Also noting after the third re-surfacing the track will need to be completely rebuilt.

Mayor Girard asked if we have three more years to build up the funds, Director Martin replied yes.

Director Martin stated he was comfortable fixing current issues and replacing the track after ten years which would be from 2018-2028.

Manager Manale noted the other two items added are City wide paving for \$200,000. Next item is the capital reserve matching funds for grant matching.

Councilor Koloski wants to have the plaque put back on the cemetery gate behind the library.

Manager Manale noted the cemetery department will look into costs.

Fire Chief Chamberlain explained the extent of the ramp paving.

Councilor Hayden questioned the costs of the Police bathroom renovations.

Manager Manale stated there were significant costs for repairs, this is an accurate price. There will be two phases, and additional costs.

Councilor O’Hearne asked about Daddy’s Pizza Lights. Manager Manale explained this was an obligation from the City due to an easement agreement.

RESOLUTION 2025-32

Supplemental Appropriations for Capital Improvements, Establishment of Grant Match Reserve, and Additional FY25 Expenses

BE IT RESOLVED by the Claremont City Council, after a public hearing duly noticed, that:

WHEREAS the City has unexpended funds in the Capital Reserve Fund for Code Enforcement and Capital Improvements (\$1,028,323) and unexpended funds in Unassigned Fund Balance (\$2,938,766); and

WHEREAS it is in the City’s best interest to fund capital projects, grant matches, and non-budgeted expenses from current cash assets, rather than raising the funds through taxation;

WHEREAS the city has an unassigned fund balance policy that encourages a maximum of 15% of the city budgeted annual appropriations in reserve;

NOW THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED by the City Council to raise and appropriate **Six Hundred Thirty-Three Thousand (\$633,000)** from the Capital Reserve Fund for Code Enforcement and Capital Improvements for the following capital improvements:

PARKING RE-LINE AND PAVING	\$100,000
SYNERGY SITE IMPROVEMENT	\$80,000
POLICE BATHROOM REPLACEMENT	\$103,000
BODY WORN CAMERA MATCH	\$40,000

BREATHING APPARATUS	\$100,000
VISITOR CENTER HVAC	\$80,000
FIRE DEPARTMENT RAMP PAVING	\$130,000
<i>Total:</i>	<i>\$633,000</i>

AND BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED by the City Council to establish an Expendable Trust Fund for Local Match of Accepted Grant Awards, and to raise and appropriate the sum of **Two-Hundred Thousand (\$200,000)** from the Capital Reserve Fund for Code Enforcement and Capital Improvements to be placed in said fund.

AND BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED by the City Council to raise and appropriate **Six Hundred Seventeen Thousand and Two-Hundred Dollars (\$617,200)** from the Unassigned General Fund Balance for the following purposes:

DOWNTOWN PARKING TRAFFIC STUDY	\$25,000
DOWNTOWN BEAUTIFICATION	\$20,000
CITY HALL WINDOW REPLACEMENT BOND	\$9,000
FY24 LEGAL FEES	\$35,000
FY24 SW COMMUNITY BUS MARKETING	\$10,000
EVERSOURCE LITIGATION	\$250,000
CYBERSECURITY AUDIT	\$15,000
AUDIT 2024	\$35,000
DADDY'S PIZZA ALLEYWAY LIGHTS	\$3,700
GODDARD BLOCK SIGNS	\$6,000
CITYWIDE PAVING	\$200,000
WALL THAT HEALS	\$8,500
MODNADNOCK TRACK	\$
<i>Total:</i>	<i>\$617,200</i>

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED to authorize the City Manager or the Treasurer, or their designees, to expend Capital Reserve Fund for Code Enforcement and Capital Improvements and Unassigned Fund Balance funds according to this resolution, with no impact to the tax rate; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City Manager, or his designees, are hereby authorized to undertake all actions and execute all documents as may be required to implement this resolution.
(Majority Vote Required)

A motion was made by Councilor Hayden and seconded by Councilor Koloski to accept Resolution 2025-32

Councilor Hayden read resolution 2025-32 into the record

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Discussion on 79-E program

Mayor Girard noted after reading the RSA’s the City hasn’t done a good job of having covenants put into place. Some programs that have been dragged out for an extended amount of time, and suggested to figure out a way to add a deadline when people are working through these programs; that way someone doesn’t finish a project ten years from now and get a tax rate set on their property for the next five to seven to even eleven years, because at that point it would affect the rest of the tax payers.

Mayor Girard also said something to work on would be the betterment of the community, and stated it’s a vague term and suggested coming up with a definition that fits with this program.

City Planner, Austin Ford stated he fully supports the deadline for the restrictive covenants, and reminded the Council 79-E is state law signed into effect and adopted by the Council, and is up to the Council’s interpretation as to what is considered the betterment of the community

Assistant Mayor Matteau asked when does clock start on the taxes freezing, does it start when the Council approves a 79-E, or at completion of a project.

City Planner Ford, stated he believes it starts at completion of the project.

Mayor Girard added on March 31st of each year the City is supposed to be going to check the building to see if its been completed, which is why there should be a covenant of what the time frame is.

Councilor Koloski brought up concerns with inspections.

City Planner Ford, explained the inspection schedule.

Councilor O’Hearne asked how many 79-Es are pending. City Planner Ford stated the applicants pending are in the packet.

Councilor Hemingway is wondering if the Council should get an annual list when 79-Es are inducted, or when they are getting ready to expire. The other concern is whether this program is being recommended to everyone that comes into this area. Councilor Hemingway noted the City needs housing and this is an incentive, but the City needs a mix of affordable, market rate, and workforce housing. The City has already covered affordable housing, and adding more would be a hinderance, suggested the need for more market value.

City Planner Ford, stated the Council can pick and choose and all the years are up to Council's discretion. Then stated this program is not being offered to everyone.

Councilor O'Hearne asked who keeps track of the 79-E's. City Planner Ford stated Assessing monitors the 79-E's.

Manager Manale looking for confirmation on what to bring back to Council.

Mayor Girard suggested needing to upgrade the guidelines before reviewing the applications.

Council agrees to send any notes, suggestions, and concerns to the City Manager.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Councilor Limoges reported the CDA had an update on 56 Opera House Square roof, and it needs to be re-bid as they need an engineer to look at the underside of the roof. 3 Tremont St. still has issues, and they also elected new officers.

Assistant Mayor Matteau reported that the Planning Board discussed driveway regulations.

Councilor Hemingway stated the Policy Committee reviewed bicycles, and the Zoning Board of Adjustments approved a retail store for the meat processing Plant.

Councilor O'Hearne added the Tolles Home is discussing recommendations for updates on bylaws, and Trustees being employees will be discussed at the next meeting.

Mayor Girard noted the Airport Committee discussed upgrades to box hangars, a grant for taxi ways project, and a weather station.

Chief Chamberlain noted the airport completed lighting upgrades in the City hangar, City beacons were removed, also discussed were land improvements, and a potential private development.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Councilor Koloski suggested a housing task force and stated he knows developers that would assist. Councilor Koloski also would like to see boards and committee recognition.

Councilor O'Hearne asked for follow up on: parking garage blue light on 4th floor, plugs from last year's snow storm, downtown lights and stated the post in front of union block is out, street lights on during day, and asked who is responsible for the Drapers Corner traffic lights.

Manager Manale stated the blue light has an order put in, and the lights and downtown electrical are being worked on. However, every time the City brings in an electrician more problems are found, and its hard to get a contractor to do the work.

Chief Chamberlain explained that Eversource is responsible for the Drapers Corner lights, and will pass it on tomorrow.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 9:27 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Councilor Limoges to adjourn.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Hemingway – yes

Zutter – yes

Hayden – yes

O'Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro
Clerk to the Council